possibly anywhere in the ancient world, against a species hierarchy favouring *Homo sapiens* and for the protection of living beings in general. The persona of Ashoka as a guardian of animals first became evident, as noted, in his major rock edicts which outline personal and public measures for animal proto-conservation: sacrifices were proscribed, the slaughter of animals for consumption in the royal kitchen drastically reduced, veterinary hospices established, provisions made for pack animals along roads. Abstention from the slaughter of life was constantly invoked. These ideas were now being inscribed in the Gangetic heartland. An older and wiser man desires an extension in the imperium of welfare to cover every species in every area of the kingdom. Here, for the first time, an entire edict is devoted to the subject—even if the policy in mind is more pragmatic than the one in the edicts recommending vegetarianism to the Afghans. The emperor seems to have realized that blanket prohibitions on hunting and fishing will not succeed and a more calibrated policy which designates some animals inviolable while allowing others to be consumed may work. There are also other measures here concerning the protection of the habitat of such living creatures and preventing unnecessary cruelty towards them. This early environmentalism is perhaps the most remarkable aspect of Ashoka's philosophy and deserves to be seen at some length:

> (When I had been) anointed twenty-six years, the following animals were declared by me inviolable, viz. parrots, mainas, the *aruna*, ruddy geese, wild geese, the *nandimukha*, the *gelata*, bats, queen-ants, terrapins, boneless fish, the *vedaveyaka*, the *Ganga-puputaka*, skate-fish, tortoises and porcupines, squirrels (?), the *srimara*, bulls set at liberty, iguanas (?), the rhinoceros, white doves, domestic doves, (and) all the quadrupeds which are neither useful nor edible.
>
> Those (she-goats), ewes, sows (which are) either with young or in milk, are inviolable, and also those (of their) young ones (which are) less than six months old.
>
> Cocks must not be caponed.
>
> Husks containing living animals must not be burnt.
>
> Forests must not be burnt uselessly or in order to destroy (living beings).